

CORSAIR

A TABLETOP ROLEPLAYING GAME

PREAMBLE: A NOTE FROM THE AUTHOR

Funnily enough, my first tabletop roleplaying game wasn't Dungeons & Dragons. It was some obscure hungarian game called M.A.G.U.S., which if anything, helped me get a feel what I don't want from a roleplaying game. My second, and the first one I learned to run as a GM was Shadowrun. You might be able to spot a few influences here and there. I thoroughly fell in love with the setting but the rules were a bit too crunchy for my taste. That's when I started to experiment with rulesets. I probably tried to hack Shadowrun to be more friendly at least three separate times if not more.

Along the lines I discovered other games, systems, and game designers, each bringing something new to the table, but my other big muse was Blades in the Dark. John Harper's brilliant work was exactly on the opposite end of the spectrum when it came to complexity. You could create a character in less than fifteen minutes if you wanted to, and both you and your group had a clear identity and goal you were working toward. I still hope one day I get to be a player and not a game master in a Forged in the Dark game. That said...

I still found myself tinkering with the rules, trying to make them more complex this time around. I realised what I really wanted was somewhere in the middle. Something that could elegantly handle all the curveballs that players could throw at it with relatively simple mechanics. And somewhere along the line I ended up thinking, "what if I tried my hand at making my own system from scratch?" This is the result of that thought.

But this is the furthest I can go on without admitting how I'm standing on the shoulders of giants. I've already mentioned Shadowrun, and Blades in the Dark, but Dungeons and Dragons, Daggerheart, the Star Wars TTRPGs by Fantasy Flight Games were all crucial inputs to the final mechanics.

As far as the setting goes, where to even begin? I loved Destiny, Horizon Zero Dawn, Mass Effect, Guardians of the Galaxy, The Expanse and many more. I knew there were many other sci-fi settings out there, but I was really hoping that this specific idea of blending space fantasy with hard sci-fi would be original enough to stand out.

That said, it would have amounted to nothing if I didn't have help. From Large Language models too, putting so much words to, well, not paper but disk, but also, those people that listened to my pitches, rants, and ramblings, and gave me feedback along the way. Who were kind enough to sit down and play this with me when it was even bigger of a mess than it is now. I know most of you never expected yourself to appear in any sort of credits, but I hope this brings you some joy, or at least a good chuckle.

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And an even bigger thanks to my wife and love of my life, **Farkas Ágnes**. I borrowed your ear more times than I can count, and you played a bigger role in making this a reality than anyone else.

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SYSTEM INTRODUCTION

THE ELEVATOR PITCH

Corsair is a tabletop roleplaying game of high-stakes frontier adventure, tactical problem-solving, and found-family camaraderie, set against the vast backdrop of a macro-engineered cosmos.

You and your crew portray a **Corsair Cell**: licensed, independent operatives flying a versatile starship with a cross-jurisdictional charter. When local planetary law ends at the clouds and the naval peacekeepers of the Flotilla are light-hours away, your sponsors call on you. Whether you are investigating corporate sabotage in a spinning orbital arcology, braving derelict Precursor ruins for lost technology, negotiating tense standoffs across a fraying border, or scraping together enough fuel credits to keep your reaction thrusters burning, your crew stands as the thin line holding a young civilization together.

WHO ARE THE CORSAIRS?

THE SPHERE AT A GLANCE

The game takes place within the **Sphere**, a breathtaking engineered solar system featuring over a hundred terrestrial, habitable worlds and moons locked in tight binary orbits around colossal gas giants, all circling a quiet Orange Dwarf star.

Circa five hundred years ago, automated seed arks brought the survivors of four dying worlds into this seemingly abandoned system. Arriving as the **Newcomers**, humanity and three alien lineages—the cold-blooded, crested **Naga**, the dense-skinned **Craggen**, and the chlorophyllic **Sylvan**—made their first historic landfall on a fertile moon appropriately named **Landfall**. Over five centuries of shared survival, exploration, and cultural blending across the moons, six natural hybrid lineages took root alongside them: **Drakelings**, **Elves**, **Gnomes**, **Dwarves**, **Kobolds**, and **Trolls**.

Today, civilization spans dozens of bustling worlds, gleaming orbital transfer stations, and remote mining habitats. Yet the laws of nature remain stubbornly grounded. There is no faster-than-light warp drive; ships burn continuous fusion engines along calculated orbital curves. There is no artificial gravity plating; you stay grounded either through the axial acceleration of your ship's thrusters, the gentle centrifugal spin of a habitat drum, or the solid click of magnetic boots against steel decks. And in the vacuum of space, waste heat is as dangerous as an enemy round.

YOUR ROLE: THE CORSAIR CELL

Civilization across the moons is divided by a historic treaty: planetary governments hold total jurisdiction within their atmospheric gravity wells, while the peacekeeping fleet known as the **Flotilla** polices the open void and interstellar shipping lanes. This separation creates a glaring legal seam. Smugglers, corporate raiders, rogue mercenaries, and political conspirators routinely commit crimes under planetary clouds and burn into orbit, daring local authorities to chase them past their legal boundaries.

To bridge this seam, authorities grant independent charters to **Corsairs**—small, autonomous crews given cross-jurisdictional warrants to cross from planetary mud to the cold vacuum of orbit without getting bogged down in red tape.

As players, you form a **Corsair Cell**—a tight-knit crew of 3 to 5 specialists sharing an agile starship. Every cell is distinct:

- **Conflicting Sponsors:** Legitimate Corsairs are typically backed by multiple, competing sponsors—such as a Flotilla naval commander, a planetary governor, a commercial trading guild, or an independent labor union. By balancing competing patrons, your crew maintains its operational independence.
- **The Omni-Role Ethos:** You are practical survivors, not rigid archetypes. While every operative has specialized training or hardware rigs, no Corsair is locked into a single duty. Every member of the crew knows how to draw a sidearm in a corridor firefight, monitor a sensor array, pilot a shuttle, patch a ruptured environmental suit, and haggle for spare parts at an orbital bazaar.
- **Freedom of Approach:** Whether your crew acts as principled investigators, gritty salvage hounds, diplomatic fixers, or razor-sharp troubleshooters, how you tackle your contracts is entirely up to you.

WHAT IS A ROLEPLAYING GAME?

A roleplaying game (RPG) is a collaborative storytelling experience. You and your friends create characters to portray, and together you navigate a living world full of adventure, intrigue, and danger.

One player takes on the role of the **Game Master (GM)**. The GM is the primary storyteller, the referee of the rules, and the voice of the non-player characters (NPCs) that inhabit the void. The other players portray the **Player Characters (PCs)**, the specialist operatives who make up the Corsair crew and drive the story forward.

The game unfolds through a natural conversation:

1. **The GM describes the situation:** The environment, the sensory details of the scene, and any imminent hazards or NPCs present.
2. **The players declare their intent:** You state what your characters do, say, or attempt—whether moving into cover, overriding an airlock seal, or negotiating terms with a tense frontier marshal.
3. **The mechanics determine uncertain outcomes:** When an action is routine, it simply succeeds. But when an outcome is uncertain, dangerous, or contested, the dice hit the table using the rules outlined in this book.
4. **The GM describes the consequences:** The fiction moves forward, the scene shifts, and the conversation continues.

There are no winners or losers in a roleplaying game. The goal is to collaborate, face tactical challenges, and tell a memorable, cinematic story together.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED TO PLAY

To play Corsair, you will need a few essentials:

TABLETOP ESSENTIALS	
Dice	The game uses three standard polyhedral die types: eight-sided (**d8**), ten-sided (**d10**), and twelve-sided (**d12**) dice. A handful of each die type (especially d10s, which form the primary resolution dice pool) is ideal for the table.
Sheets	Printable sheets for recording your operative's attributes, skills, equipment, and your starship's modules (Character Sheet & Crew Sheet).
Pencils	Pencils and scratch paper for tracking notes, tactical sketches, and fluctuating game states (Action Points, Light Wounds, Aggravated Wounds, and ammunition).
Tokens	Simple counters (coins, poker chips, or glass beads) are useful for tracking Action Points and tactical positions during moment-to-moment encounters.
Group	Corsair is designed for **3 to 5 players**, including the Game Master.

> **THE PRINCIPLE OF NARRATION**
>
> Dice never roll in a vacuum. A roll represents physical friction: boots catching against grated decking, capacitors whining under peak load, or thruster gimbal bearings fighting reaction torque. Describe what your character physically does before picking up the dice.

READER'S GUIDE: HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

This rulebook is organized into five functional sections designed to take you from foundational mechanics to active campaign play, interleaved with narrative fiction capturing the lived reality of the void:

PART I: CORE RULES & ENGINE

The fundamental mechanics that power every test, decision, and scene in the game.

- **Core Mechanics:** The foundational rules of Attributes, Attribute Pairs, Simple Tests (binary success), Success Tests (degree of achievement), Complex Tests (action + quality), Upgrades & Downgrades, Contests, Gambits, and Teamwork.
- **Scenes, Pacing & Action Points:** Zooming between Day-to-Day shifts and high-stakes Moment-to-Moment rounds, the 3 Action Point economy, turn swaps, teamwork actions, and delayed actions.
- **Effects:** Activating dynamic tactical opportunities by sacrificing Hits on Action Rolls (Chain, Upgrade/Downgrade, Blocker) and Success Rolls (Crit, Push).
- **Interlude:** *A Point of Order on the Twenty-Seventh Hour*

PART II: CHARACTER CREATION & CLASSES

Everything you need to conceive, build, and advance your Corsair operative.

- **Player Characters:** Core Attributes, Derived Attributes, Skills, and Condition (wounds and stress).
- **Character Creation:** Step-by-step procedures for assigning attributes, training skills, and choosing starting equipment.
- **Traits & Lineages:** Origin traits, cultural adaptations, and operational quirks that distinguish your operative's physiology and background.
- **Classes & MANTLE Rigs:** The five operational chassis: the energy-channeling **Conduit**, the biochemical **Hazard**, the drone-linking **Pilot**, the frontline bulwark **Vanguard**, and the nanite-weaving **Weaver**.
- **Advancement:** How operatives earn experience, refine skills, upgrade attributes, and achieve career milestones during downtime.
- **Interlude:** *Post War Head- and Heartaches*

PART III: ADVANCED OPERATIONS

The tactical systems, armaments, voidcraft, and operational downtime that keep Corsairs alive and solvent.

- **Tactical Combat:** Movement, grid and abstract occupancy, close-quarters combat (CQC), dynamic cover, and damage resolution.
- **Personal Armory & Hardware:** Catalogs of Firearms, Melee Weapons, Armor, Field Gear, and rare Precursor Exotic Hardware.
- **Starships & Space Combat:** Comprehensive rules for Starship Operations, Brachistochrone burns, Ship Weapons, Internal Modules, and The Hangar Bay.
- **Downtime & Operations:** The 24-hour downtime cycle, shifts, long rests, medical recovery, starship maintenance, commercial bazaars, and the master d100 freelance odd jobs table.
- **Interlude:** *The Mathematics of the Great Tithe*

PART IV: WORLDS OF THE SPHERE

The celestial gazetteer, faction dossiers, history, and fiction of the setting.

- **Planetary Gazetteer:** Macro-engineering of the Sphere, the Newcomer heartland in the Fume Cluster, the cradle of Landfall, and the X'ara Cluster.
- **Factions & Powers:** Dossiers on the Sovereign Colonies, Megacorporations, the Flotilla, and the Underworld.
- **The Corsairs & Timeline:** The legal mandate of Corsairs, the 500-year history since arrival, and master anthology Stories of the Sphere.
- **Interlude:** *Space Tourism*

PART V: RUNNING THE GAME

Procedures, campaign structures, threat rosters, and mission generators for running the game.

- **Running the Game:** Core guidelines for Time Management, Social Interactions, Stealth & Infiltration, Investigation, Chases & Pursuits, and Tracks.
- **Threats of the Sphere:** Tactical profiles and statblocks for corporate security, pirates, drone swarms, void horrors, and NPC Guidelines.
- **Missions & Contracts:** Procedural Mission Generator and Open Play Contracts.

> **FLIGHT CLEARANCE APPROVED**
> Proceed to the foundational resolution mechanics: **Chapter 01: Core Mechanics →**

CORE MECHANICS & RESOLUTION

In Corsair, the story unfolds through a conversation between the players and the Game Master (GM). The players narrate the actions of their characters, describing what they want to do, where they want to go, and what they say. The GM, in turn, narrates the world around the characters. The GM describes the environment, controls the non-player characters, and explains how the world reacts to the players' actions.

Most of the time, this back-and-forth is all that's needed. If a player says, *"I walk across the room and open the door,"* and there's no reason they couldn't, the GM simply says, *"Okay, you open the door and see..."*

However, sometimes a character attempts an action where the outcome is uncertain. Can the character leap across a chasm? Can they persuade a fugitive with a gun to stand down? Can they land a hit with their sidearm if they don't? In these moments, when the drama and tension of the story hang in the balance, we turn to the dice to see what happens. This is the heart of the game's mechanics, and it's where the rules of Corsair come into play.

ATTRIBUTES

In Corsair, any significant feature of a person, creature, or object can be represented by an **Attribute**. Attributes are a way to assign a numerical value to a characteristic, making it a concrete element of the game world. Anything and everything can have Attributes.

While characters have core Attributes representing their physical and mental capabilities—**Strength**, **Agility**, **Finesse**, **Instinct**, **Knowledge**, and **Presence**—the concept extends to all corners of the game:

- **Strength:** Raw physical power, muscular force, and bodily mass. Used for lifting heavy cargo, forcing jammed airlocks, overpowering opponents in hand-to-hand combat, and carrying heavy equipment.
- **Agility:** Whole-body speed, balance, and athletic coordination. Used for sprinting between cover, dodging incoming hazards, vaulting obstacles, and maneuvering in zero-gravity.
- **Finesse:** Manual dexterity, surgical precision, and fine motor control. Used for aiming firearms, picking mechanical locks, performing delicate surgery, and manipulating intricate instruments.
- **Knowledge:** Formal education, technical literacy, and deductive reasoning. Used for slicing computer security, analyzing sensor telemetry, operating starship consoles, and understanding alien relics.
- **Presence:** Force of personality, charisma, and commanding social authority. Used for negotiating deals, intimidating rivals, inspiring companions, and maintaining composure under intense pressure.
- **Instinct:** Intuition, acute situational alertness, and gut-level reflexes. Used for sensing impending ambushes, detecting hidden hazards, reading an adversary's unspoken intent, and reacting in the chaos of battle.

Beyond living characters, the concept of Attributes extends to all corners of the game. A weapon might have **Rate of Fire** and **Accuracy** as Attributes. A jetpack could have a **Thrust** Attribute, while a cybernetic arm might have a **Power** rating. A starship is defined by a whole range of Attributes, such as its **Thrusters**, **Hull**, and **Scanners**. These ratings are the primary factor in determining the outcome of an action. A higher Attribute value signifies greater capability, directly impacting the dice rolls you'll make during the game.

ATTRIBUTE PAIRS

When a situation calls for a die roll, the GM will determine the two most relevant Attributes to form an **Attribute Pair**. This pair becomes the foundation of the test. The choice of Attributes is always dependent on the context of the action being performed.

It's important to note that the same Attribute can be selected twice if the action calls for a focused application of that single quality. For example, lifting a heavy crate might call for a **Strength + Strength** test, representing a pure application of raw power. Additionally, when a test specifies only a single Attribute, it should be understood as a test where both Attributes in the Attribute Pair are that specified Attribute.

Here are a few examples of how these might be combined into Attribute Pairs:

- **Accuracy (of the gun) + Finesse:** To fire a ranged weapon.
- **Manouverability (of the spaceship) + Instinct:** To carefully pilot a shuttle through a dense asteroid field.
- **Strength + Presence:** To intimidate a guard with a show of force.
- **Knowledge + Instinct:** To investigate a crime scene, look for clues and deduce what happened.

TESTS

When the outcome of an action is uncertain, the GM will call for a test. There are three types of tests in Corsair: **Simple**, **Success**, and **Complex**.

SIMPLE TESTS

A Simple Test is used when the outcome of an action is binary: you either succeed or you fail. There is no middle ground. To make a Simple Test, you form a dice pool by taking a number of ten-sided dice (d10s) equal to the higher of the two Attributes in the pair. In order to succeed, you need at least one of the dice to roll an 8 or higher (also called a *Hit*). If it does, you succeed; if it doesn't, you fail.

Examples of Simple Tests include:

- Leaping across a chasm.
- Sneaking through a patrolled corridor.
- Disarming a trap.

SUCCESS TESTS

A Success Test is used for actions that are certain to succeed, but the degree of success is variable. The question isn't *if* you can do it, but *how well* you do it in the time available. For a Success Test, you form a dice pool using a number of d10s equal to the *higher* of the two Attributes in the pair. The highest single die roll from the pool becomes your **success points**, which measures how effectively you performed the action.

Examples of Success Tests include:

- Applying first aid to a wounded crewmate to see how many wounds you can patch up.
- Spending a day in the workshop repairing your ship to see how much progress you make.
- Moving around the battlefield and seeing how much distance you cover.

COMPLEX TESTS

Complex Tests are for situations where you need to know both *if* an action is successful and *how* successful it is. This is most common in combat, where you need to know if an attack hits and, if it does, how much damage it deals. A Complex Test is a two-step process:

1. **The Action Roll:** First, you make a roll to see if you succeed at all. This is identical to a Simple Test: you roll a number of d10s equal to the **higher** of the two Attributes in the pair. If your highest die is a 7 or lower, your action fails.
2. **The Success Roll:** If your Action Roll is a success (at least one die shows 8 or higher), you then determine the *quality* of your success. You take a number of dice from the successful roll equal to the **lower** of the two Attributes. The highest value on these dice becomes your "success points."

Essentially, a Complex Test combines a Simple Test to see if you hit, and a Success Test to see how well you hit.

THE IMPORTANCE OF NARRATION

It is crucial to understand that the GM determines the type of test and the Attribute Pair based on *how you describe your character's actions*. Your narration matters. The choices you make in describing an action can change the Attributes used, and therefore the dice you roll.

For example, let's say your character is trying to persuade an NPC:

- If you say, *"I try to reason with him, surely he will see my point in all this,"* the GM will call for a **Presence + Knowledge** test, splashing in Knowledge for the reasoning part.
- If you instead say, *"I put on all the charm my character has and try to appeal to him that way,"* the GM will call for a **Presence + Presence** test.
- If you narrate, *"I get all up in his face and make it very clear to him in no uncertain terms that he will do as I say,"* the GM will call for a **Strength + Presence** test.
- And if you instead say, *"I hold my gun to his head and start counting,"* the GM could still ask for the **Damage** or the **Load** (size) of the gun and say roll that plus your **Presence**.

UPGRADES AND DOWNGRADES

Situational factors can influence the outcome of a test. A character might have a significant advantage, like using a high-quality tool, or a disadvantage, like working in a hazardous environment. These are represented by **Upgrades** and **Downgrades**:

- **Upgrade:** For each net **Upgrade**, you change one of the d10s in your dice pool to a twelve-sided die (d12). If all the dice in your pool are already d12s, each further **Upgrade** adds a new d10 to the pool.
- **Downgrade:** For each net **Downgrade**, you change one of the d10s in your dice pool to an eight-sided die (d8). If all the dice in your pool are already d8s, each further **Downgrade** forces you to remove a d8 from the pool.

Before any roll, the GM assesses the situation and assigns Upgrades for advantages and Downgrades for disadvantages. These cancel each other out on a 1-to-1 basis (e.g., 3 Upgrades and 2 Downgrades yields a net of 1 Upgrade).

The net number of Upgrades or Downgrades has a **maximum limit of 6**. If you have 8 Upgrades and 1 Downgrade, you have a net of 7 Upgrades, but you apply only 6 to the roll. In the rare case that you run out of all dice to downgrade, the test is extremely difficult: you roll two d8s and must take the lower result.

THE GAMBIT SYSTEM

Gambit is a special resource that allows players to snatch victory from the jaws of defeat. It's a pool of dice that you can use to turn a failed roll into a success.

EARNING GAMBIT

You earn **Gambit** by taking risks. After you roll your dice pool for a test, if any die shows its maximum possible value (e.g., a 10 on a d10, or a 12 on a d12), you have a choice. You can either use that die as part of your test as normal, or you can "bank" it for later. If you choose to bank it, you remove the die from your current roll and add it to your personal **Gambit** pool. This die can then be spent on a future roll.

SPENDING GAMBIT

You can spend a **Gambit** die from your pool on any test your character makes. You can declare you are spending **Gambit** at any point during the test—before you roll, after you see the results, anytime. When you spend a **Gambit** die, you simply add it to your current dice pool and roll it. Its result is added to the other dice, potentially changing the outcome of the test.

When a player spends a **Gambit** die, and the dice pool has already been modified by **Upgrades** or **Downgrades**, the newly added **Gambit** die retains its original die type.

THE GOLDEN RULE OF GAMBIT

There is one crucial restriction on using **Gambit**: **a player can either spend or gain Gambit during a test, but not both.** This means that if you spend any **Gambit** from your pool on a test, you cannot choose to bank any dice from that test to earn new **Gambit**. Conversely, if you bank a die from a roll to earn a **Gambit**, you cannot spend any **Gambit** on that same test.

PUTTING IT ALL TOGETHER: AN EXAMPLE TEST

Let's see how all these elements come together in play:

- **The Scenario:** Serving an apprehension warrant against an armed syndicate cell in an unpoliced orbital warehouse, Jax, a nimble gunslinger, is pinned down behind a cargo container. An outlaw skirmisher is advancing on his position, laying down suppressing fire. Jax decides to pop up and take a quick shot at the suspect with his sidearm. The GM decides this is a **Complex Test**, as they need to know if the shot hits and how much damage it deals. Jax's player describes the action as a quick, precise shot, so the GM chooses the Attribute Pair: **Finesse + Accuracy**. Jax has **Finesse 4**, his sidearm has **Accuracy 3**, and he holds two d10s in his Gambit pool.
- **1. The Action Roll (Did the shot hit?):** For the first part of a Complex Test, Jax uses the higher of the two Attributes (**Finesse 4**), assembling a dice pool of **4d10**. He rolls `[2, 4, 5, 7]`. The highest result is 7 (a miss). Jax spends a Gambit die: *"I'm spending a Gambit."* He rolls the banked d10 and gets an `[8]`. His pool is now `[2, 4, 5, 7, 8]`. With an 8, the shot hits!
- **2. The Success Roll (How much damage was dealt?):** For the second part of a Complex Test, Jax uses the lower Attribute (**Accuracy 3**), taking the 3 highest dice from his pool: `[5, 7, 8]`. The highest die is an 8 (8 points of damage). Jax decides to maximize the damage: *"I'm spending my second Gambit die."* He rolls his second banked d10 and rolls a `[9]`. His Success pool is now `[5, 7, 8, 9]`. The highest result is a 9.
- **Resolution:** Jax deals 9 points of damage to the outlaw, taking them down before they can breach his cover. Spending his banked Gambit turned a clean miss into a devastating shot.

CONTESTING A TEST

Often, a test isn't just against a static obstacle; it's against an active opponent who is trying to interfere. When a character is the target of another character's test (like being shot at, deceived, or tackled), they have the opportunity to contest.

In order to contest an action taken by another creature, you must be in close physical proximity to its target—typically sharing the immediate space with them. For example, you can contest an attack coming at you or an ally right beside you, and you can contest an enemy's movement crossing your space. On the other hand, you cannot contest a hostile creature reviving an ally 40 meters away by shooting at them.

To perform a **Contest**, the defending creature rolls a **Simple Test** determined by the GM (called a **Contest Roll**). Each die landing **8 or higher (a Hit)** eliminates the highest die from the roll you contested.

You **resist** a test if your Contest Roll eliminates every 8+ die from the contested roll.

You can contest **Success Tests** as well. If, after contesting, no 8+ dice remain in the contested character's pool, the Success Test generates **0 Success Points**, even if there are dice that are yet to be eliminated.

You can also contest actions that would normally not require a test (such as shushing someone before they can speak, or preventing an enemy you knocked prone from standing up). When this happens, you declare your intent to contest, and the contested creature must decide if they are willing to perform a **Simple Test** to complete their action—which you can then contest—or forego it altogether.

CONTEST EXAMPLE

Returning to our gunslinger Jax: suppose Jax fires at a fleeing syndicate smuggler trying to reach an airlock, rolling `[2, 4, 5, 7, 8]`. The suspect has an **Evasion** of 3 and dives behind reinforced deck piping. The GM calls for an Evasion Contest Roll (**3d10**). The smuggler rolls `[3, 8, 9]`—scoring two Hits (8 and 9). These two Hits eliminate Jax's two highest dice (the 8 and the 7). Jax's remaining pool is `[2, 4, 5]`. With no die of 8 or higher remaining, the attack becomes a **Failure**; the round ricochets harmlessly off the reinforced piping as the suspect scrambles out of the line of fire.

TEAMWORK

Sometimes, a single character isn't enough for the job. When multiple characters cooperate on the same task at the same time—forcing open a hydraulic blast door, infiltrating past a vigilant patrol, or executing a coordinated breach—they can use **Teamwork**.

JOINING A TEAMWORK ACTION

Any character's action can be turned into a **Teamwork Test** by additional eligible characters declaring their intent to join. A character can join a Teamwork action if:

- **Proximity:** The participants are in close physical proximity to each other and their shared objective.
- **Appropriate Contribution:** Each participant rolls the Attribute Pair appropriate to their weapon, gear, or method of action. Participants do not need to roll the same Attribute Pair! For example, two characters forcing a heavy blast door might both roll **Strength + Strength**, but in a coordinated combat assault, one character might swing a warhammer (**Strength + Finesse**, Striking) while an ally thrusts with a combat knife (**Agility + Finesse**, Piercing). Because all tests evaluate Hits on an 8 or higher, dice can be swapped freely between pools regardless of which attributes generated them.
- **Shared Target or Objective:** If the action has a target or destination, it must be identical for all participants (firing on the same enemy, treating the same wounded ally, forcing the same bulkhead).
- **Logical Feasibility:** The task must be something that multiple people can realistically cooperate on simultaneously.

THE DICE SWAP

After all participants declare their intent to cooperate, everyone rolls their respective test pools simultaneously. Once the dice hit the table, **any two participants can swap any amount of dice between their pools**. The strategic purpose of this exchange is mutual support: characters with surplus high-value dice (8+) pass extra results to allies who rolled low, ensuring the entire team achieves its goal or shaves away vulnerabilities.

CONTESTING TEAMWORK: DEFENDER'S ADVANTAGE

When an adversary is targeted by a Teamwork action, the defender gains the **Defender's Advantage**:

1. **Team Rolls:** All attacking participants roll their dice pools simultaneously.
2. **Team Swaps:** Attackers coordinate and commit their dice distribution.
3. **Defender Rolls:** The defender rolls their Contest pool *after* the attackers commit their dice swap.
4. **Targeted Elimination:** Each Hit (8+) on the Contest Roll allows the defender to eliminate the highest die from **whichever participating attacker's pool the defender chooses**. The defender can focus all Hits onto a single attacker to knock them out of the test, or split Hits across multiple foes.
5. **Knocking Attackers Out:** In a Complex Test, if the defender eliminates all 8+ dice from an attacker's pool, that attacker fails their Action Roll completely and **cannot advance to the Success Roll**. Only attackers who retain an 8+ move forward to roll damage!

COMPLEX TESTS & CONTESTS IN TEAMWORK

Teamwork can be employed across both stages of a Complex Test. Surviving attackers roll their Success pools and may **swap dice between their Success pools as well**, funneling high dice onto an operative with high-damage weapons or critical effects.

Defenders can also use Teamwork to resist incoming actions: when multiple defenders coordinate to resist an action, they roll their contest pools simultaneously, swap dice to maximize total

SCENES, PACING, AND ACTION

Corsair's gameplay is structured to keep the action moving and give every character a chance to shine. The story unfolds in Scenes, which are the fundamental building blocks of your adventure. However, not all scenes are paced the same. The GM can control the narrative flow by "zooming in" or "zooming out" on the action, changing the scope of a scene from a single, heart-pounding moment to the events of an entire day.

The game distinguishes between three types of scenes based on their scope: **Moment to Moment**, **Place to Place**, and **Day to Day**.

SCENE TYPES AND PACING

Think of the scene type as a camera lens. The GM can zoom in for a close-up on a dramatic confrontation or zoom out to quickly cover a long journey:

- **Day to Day:** This is the most "zoomed-out" level of play. It's used to cover long periods of time in which the characters are engaged in ongoing activities, but nothing requires immediate, second-by-second attention. This could be a day spent repairing the ship, a week of interstellar travel, or a month of downtime in a bustling city.
- **Place to Place:** This is the mid-level scope, focusing on a specific location and the events that unfold there. It's used for exploring a space station, navigating a dangerous asteroid field, or investigating a crime scene. Time is more fluid here than in Moment to Moment play, but the focus is on a single, contiguous area.
- **Moment to Moment:** This is the most "zoomed-in" level of play, where every second counts. This is for high-stakes situations like combat, a frantic chase, or a tense negotiation.

ACTION POINTS

Action Points are the currency you spend to perform significant actions, especially those requiring a Test. Every player has a maximum of **3 Action Points**.

Every test you take, whether it be Simple, Success, or Complex, requires **1 Action Point**. In some cases the GM might also call on you to spend an Action Point without taking a test, for example, to transit from one major location to the next.

ROUNDS

Within any scene, the action is broken down into **Rounds**. A round is a period of in-game time appropriate to the scene's pacing, where every character present has an opportunity to act. This ensures that the chaos of a situation is manageable and that the spotlight is shared.

A round in moment-to-moment pacing is only a dozen or so seconds long. In place-to-place pacing, a round might last from minutes to a few hours, while in day-to-day pacing, it's a full day.

At the start of every Round, every creature refills their Action Points to the maximum.

When the round ends, the GM gets an opportunity to introduce new characters into the scene, based on the broader scope of the scene that's playing out and the amount of time that passed during the round. This can be new reinforcements arriving in a moment-to-moment gunfight, or an inspection from the local authorities while you are going place-to-place. This also lets the GM advance the plot via NPCs that are acting outside the ongoing scene.

TURNS

Each round is divided into multiple turns of two different types: The **Player Turn** and the **GM Turn**.

- **Player Turn:** During the Player Turn, the players decide and declare what their characters are doing. A crucial aspect of the Player Turn is its free-form nature. **Players can act in any order they wish.** You can coordinate your actions, set up combos, and react to each other's decisions dynamically. One player might act, then another, then the first player might act again.
- **GM Turn:** During the GM Turn, the Game Master narrates the actions of the non-player characters (NPCs) in the scene. This is when every NPC makes their moves. If there are no NPCs in the scene other than the players, the GM turn is skipped, and it's the Player's Turn again.

The turn swaps from the players to the GM (or vice versa) after the active side has spent a total of **2 or more Action Points** and resolved their last action. The round concludes when both sides choose to "pass," meaning they have no further actions to take. Every round starts with the Player Turn first.

Most rounds will fly by due to the players being grounded with no NPCs, or NPCs that generally don't wish to affect the player characters. Therefore, most rounds will be rather one-sided, but that is a good thing as the GM already has a lot of work just arbitrating the player characters' narrations.

When a player action causes an NPC to go from a passive to an active participant in the scene, they become active and receive their Action Points next round, meaning each player character has a chance to act before the GM gets to react with NPCs.

GOING FIRST

Every round begins with the Player Turn. The players always act first, coordinating their moves and executing their strategies before the GM responds with the actions of non-player characters.

TEAMWORK ACTIONS

Teamwork allows multiple characters to contribute to a single goal. When characters use Teamwork, they can spend their Action Points to contribute to the collective effort. While players spending Action Points to participate in a Teamwork Test counts towards the 2AP per Turn limit, reaching the limit doesn't stop additional characters from participating. The turn will only end once the Teamwork Test has resolved.

TEAMWORK EXAMPLE: CHECKPOINT INFILTRATION

The crew is working an undercover assignment tracking a fugitive into an outlaw-run freeport. To reach the lower docks without tipping off the local syndicate, they must pass through an enforcer-controlled checkpoint. The GM rules this will be a Teamwork action, requiring each character to make a Success Test to see how well they blend into the underworld foot traffic:

- Silas, a master of disguise, creates a subtle diversion at a cargo terminal and scores 2 hits.
- Griz, a large and imposing figure, tries to look inconspicuous by pretending to be an off-shift maintenance hauler, but fails miserably, scoring no hits.
- Jax, ever the opportunist, strikes up a casual conversation with one of the gang lookouts to draw their attention, scoring just one hit.

The players have now collectively spent 3 Action Points. Silas swaps one of his hits for one of Griz's dice, representing the operatives covering for each other's slip-ups and successfully slipping past the checkpoint as a cohesive unit.

The flexibility of the turn structure and Action Point system is designed to encourage creative problem-solving and dynamic, cinematic action. Don't be afraid to combine actions, work together, and push your characters to their limits.

DELAYED ACTIONS

During high-stakes encounters, characters do not always act immediately; often, a disciplined Corsair holds their fire until an enemy leaves cover, waits for an incoming threat to breach a threshold, or readies a shot to interrupt a hostile move. You can prepare for such moments by declaring a **Delayed Action**:

- **Setting Up (1 AP):** On your turn, you spend **1 Action Point** to prepare a delayed action. When declaring a delayed action, you must specify two things:
  1. **The Trigger:** The observable event or condition you are reacting to (e.g., *"when an enemy steps out of cover," "if Brant draws a sidearm,"* or *"when the blast door starts to open"*).
  2. **The Planned Action:** The specific action you intend to take when the trigger occurs. The planned action must be manageable within **1 AP** (such as taking a shot with a firearm, swinging a melee weapon, making a Simple Test, or moving up to your base movement distance).
- **Declaring Timing (Before vs. After):** You have tactical freedom over when your action resolves relative to the trigger, but you must declare your timing beforehand when setting it up:
  - **Reacting Before (Interrupt):** You act *before* the triggering event resolves. For instance, declaring that you will shoot at a target the moment they attempt to fire at you allows you to shoot first, potentially eliminating or disrupting them before their attack can land.
  - **Reacting After (Response):** You act *after* the triggering event has completed. For instance, waiting until an enemy has moved completely out from behind heavy cover into open ground before firing ensures they cannot claim cover bonuses against your attack.
- **Action Point & Turn Accounting:** The 1 AP cost is paid **on the turn you set up the delayed action**, counting against the 2 AP limit of that turn. When the trigger condition occurs and you take your action, it requires **0 additional AP** in that moment, and it does not count against the AP limit of the turn in which it triggers.
- **Resolution and Expiration:** When the trigger condition is met, you immediately execute the declared test or action. If the triggering condition does not occur before the end of the round, the prepared action expires without effect—the spent Action Point represents the time, readiness, and vigilance invested in holding your position.
- **Delayed Teamwork Actions:** Multiple characters can coordinate to set up a shared delayed action (such as establishing a crossfire overwatch or setting a synchronized ambush):
  - **Setup:** All participants must share the same space, spend **1 AP** each, and agree upon the exact same **Trigger**, **Target**, and **Timing** (Before or After). Each participant prepares the action and Attribute Pair appropriate to their weapon or tool. An ally can spend 1 AP on a subsequent turn to join an existing ally's delayed action if they enter their space.
  - **Triggering & Swapping:** When the trigger condition occurs, all linked participants roll simultaneously for **0 additional AP** and can swap dice between their pools under standard Teamwork rules. If the target contests, Defender's Advantage applies normally.
  - **Disruption:** If an individual participant is incapacitated, knocked out of the space, or forced to defend before the trigger occurs, their readied action is broken, but remaining allies can still execute their delayed action when the condition is met.

ZOOMING IN AND OUT

The GM can transition between scene types as the story demands:

- **Zooming In:** When a broader scene suddenly becomes more dangerous or dramatic, the GM can "zoom in." For example, while the crew is executing a recovery warrant aboard an abandoned freighter (Place to Place), they might be ambushed by barricaded pirate scavengers, instantly shifting the scene to Moment to Moment. When zooming in, all characters present in the scene synchronize their broader Action Points down to the lowest remaining AP among them (reflecting time elapsed together). They then refill their Action Points in the new, narrower pacing to their maximum (3 AP) and begin a fresh round. Any ongoing effects created in the broader pacing are retained.
- **Zooming Out:** When a high-stakes scene concludes, the GM "zooms out" back to the broader pacing. Players set aside their tactical Action Points and resume the broader pacing with their remaining broader Action Points. If characters still have Action Points remaining in that broader round, they continue their shift or day; if all broader AP have been spent, the broader round concludes at the End of the Round. Characters operating in parallel in other locations retain their unspent broader AP and can take actions during that same timeframe.

EFFECTS

While succeeding at a test achieves your immediate objective, game mechanics in Corsair invite you to shape the battleground, create tactical openings, and alter the narrative flow of a scene. This is accomplished through Effects. Rather than relying solely on standard outcomes, Effects allow you to convert exceptional rolls into dynamic opportunities—turning a single strike into a sweeping attack, driving an opponent backward, or setting up a defensive barrier for an ally.

ACTIVATING EFFECTS

To activate an Effect, you sacrifice **Hits**—dice displaying a result of 8 or higher—rolled during an Action Roll or a Success Roll, depending on the specific Effect's requirements.

Activating an Effect is an exercise in collaborative storytelling between you and the Game Master. The Effect you declare must align logically with your character's action, declared narration, and chosen Attribute Pair. For instance, you cannot use an attack roll with a rifle to push a heavy blast door shut across the room, but you could easily describe forcing an enemy backward into cover or shooting out a control panel. The GM retains final discretion on whether an Effect fits naturally into the unfolding fiction.

ACTION EFFECTS

Action Effects are activated during your **Action Roll**. By setting aside Hits before moving on to resolve your Success Roll, you can manipulate the immediate environment or extend the reach of your action:

- **Chain Effect:** When performing an action directed at a single target out of several eligible choices—most commonly during combat—you may spend Hits on a **Chain Effect**. For each Hit you sacrifice from your Action Roll, you select one additional eligible target to include in the action. When chaining a Complex Test, perform a single Success Roll using the lower Attribute; the highest die applies individually to every target caught in the chain. You cannot chain actions that naturally affect multiple targets by default. Furthermore, if the base action requires expending a specific resource (such as ammunition, power cells, or consumable gear), you must pay that resource cost separately for each chained target. When making a ranged attack, you can only chain targets in the same range band, and the combined use of Chain and Crit effects cannot exceed your weapon's Rate of Fire (RoF).
- **Upgrade and Downgrade Effect:** When your action creates a clear situational advantage for yourself or an impending disadvantage for an enemy, you can activate an **Upgrade or Downgrade Effect**. Each Hit spent from your Action Roll allows you to step up or step down a die on subsequent tests related to that altered circumstance. Crucially, if you are resolving a Complex Test, you may apply this effect immediately to step up dice on your own upcoming Success Roll without needing to specify the situational advantage.
- **Blocker Effect:** If your narration aims to hinder, interrupt, or prevent an enemy from carrying out a specific future action, you can establish a **Blocker Effect**. For every **2 Hits** you sacrifice from your Action Roll, you set aside 1 Hit to create a pool of defensive dice. When an opponent attempts the blocked action, each set-aside Hit negates the single highest die from their test pool before resolving. Once a set-aside Hit negates an opponent's die, that set-aside Hit is expended. The Blocker Effect persists until all set-aside Hits are exhausted. If an opponent attempts to perform an action that normally does not require a test (such as opening a latch or standing up), the Blocker forces them to execute a **Simple Test** first; failing to eliminate all set-aside Hits prevents them from completing the action.

SUSTAINED EFFECTS

Certain Effects can be sustained over time rather than depleting after a single use. An Effect can become a **Sustained Effect** whenever there is an active physical object (such as magnetic restraints, deployed gear, a smoke screen, or specialized equipment) or an ongoing continuous action sustaining it.

When an Effect is sustained, any set-aside Hits or mechanical benefits do not deplete when triggered. Instead, the full pool of set-aside Hits or advantages resets after each affected action or attempt. Sustained Effects can be applied to any Effect type where continuous operation makes logical narrative sense—most commonly Blocker Effects or ongoing Upgrade/Downgrade Effects. A Sustained Effect remains active until an opponent succeeds despite the penalty or until the physical object or continuous action sustaining it is removed, destroyed, or neutralized.

SUCCESS EFFECTS

Success Effects are activated during your **Success Roll**, allowing you to amplify the effectiveness or intensity of an action that has already proven successful:

- **Crit Effect:** The primary Success Effect across all Success Rolls. For every Hit (8+) sacrificed from your Success Roll pool, you add **+2 Success Points** directly to your highest remaining die value.
- **Push Effect:** Leverage raw momentum or physical force to reposition a target. For each Hit sacrificed from your Success Roll, you knock or force the target backward by up to 4 meters. If you wish to maintain pressure or stay in close proximity, you may move along with the target as they are displaced without spending additional movement. Push Effects can only be activated if **Strength** (or a similar physical power attribute) is included in the test's Attribute Pair; they cannot be activated with tests relying solely on finesse, mental, or social attributes.

REMOVING EFFECTS

Ongoing environmental hazards, physical restraints, and persistent blockers do not have to remain forever. If a character is in a position to eliminate or neutralize an active ongoing effect, they may spend **1 Action Point** on their turn to make a **Simple Test** determined by the GM. Each Hit scored on this Simple Test removes 1 set-aside Hit from the targeted effect, gradually breaking down the obstacle until it is completely eliminated.

COMBINED MECHANICS IN ACTION

COMBINED MECHANICS IN ACTION: SYNDICATE CACHE BREACH

Acting under a Flotilla interdiction warrant, Jax and his team are raiding a fortified syndicate contraband cache defended by illegal combat drones. Engaging in close-quarters combat at the breached bulkhead, Jax declares, "I step in and swing my axe in a sweeping melee strike across the lead combat drone to tear open its plating while driving it back into its squadmate to clear the entryway."

The GM assesses the melee action and calls for a **Strength (5) + Strength (5)** Complex Test. Jax rolls 5d10 for his Action Roll based on his higher Attribute (**Strength 5**), producing `[3, 5, 8, 8, 9]`.

With three Hits (8, 8, and 9), Jax spends one Hit (8) to activate an Action Effect—an **Upgrade Effect**—stepping up one die on his upcoming Success Roll from a d10 to a **d12**. He leaves his remaining Hits (8 and 9) to ensure his Action Roll succeeds.

Moving to his Success Roll for his lower Attribute (**Strength 5**), Jax rolls 4d10 and 1d12 (modified by his Upgrade Effect). His roll yields `[5, 6, 7, 8]` on the d10s and 8 on the d12.

Jax scores two Hits (both 8s) on his Success Roll. He decides to activate two Success Effects:

- He spends his first 8 to activate a **Push Effect** (valid since his test relies on Strength), shoving the lead combat drone back 4 meters directly into its squadmate.
- He spends his second 8 to activate a **Crit Effect**, granting **+2 Success Points** to his highest remaining die.

The highest remaining die on his Success Roll is 7. By sacrificing his second 8 for Crit instead of keeping it as his base die, Jax increases his total from 8 to **9 Success Points** (7 + 2 = 9), neutralizing the lead drone while driving it clear of the doorway.

A POINT OF ORDER ON THE TWENTY-SEVENTH HOUR

A CORSAIR STORY • FICTION INTERLUDE

Jesse Haddon was fifty-eight years old, which was old enough to know that the universe was enormously large, profoundly strange, and mostly interested in generating paperwork.

As Speaker of the Crossroads Council, Jesse sat behind a heavy cedar table that he had planed and varnished with his own two hands thirty years ago. Outside the high arched windows, the twin world of Nimbus—a swirling sphere of purple and gold sixty thousand miles across—was casually drifting across the afternoon sky toward the sun. In about twenty minutes, it would block the light entirely. The thirty-hour day would pause, the valley would plunge into a sudden, freezing twilight, and the gas lamps out in the square would click on for *The Pause*.

To a poet, it was an awe-inspiring celestial dance. To Jesse, it meant he had exactly twenty minutes to get five very stubborn people to agree on a ditch before the room went dark and his tea went cold.

"It is not merely a question of the ditch," Councilwoman Vaelith was saying, leaning forward until her leafy green hair brushed the ceiling beams. She was an eight-foot-tall Sylvan elder with magnificent wooden tusks, peering down her nose through a pair of tiny brass spectacles. "It is a question of common decency. The new rocket shuttles taking off from the south field are blowing black soot all over the valley. My people hang their bedsheets out to dry in the morning, and by noon they look like chimney sweeps. My cousin's boy had to get married in a grey tunic, Jesse. A *grey* tunic."

On the other side of the table, Brom of the Stone-Carvers Guild gave a long, gravelly sigh that sounded like a wheelbarrow of river rocks being tipped into a creek. Brom was a Craggen, which meant his skin was solid grey granite, his eyes were cut gemstones, and his patience was measured in centuries.

"The shuttles carry iron sewer pipes," Brom rumbled, tapping a thick stone finger on his ledger. "Caldera Foundry makes the pipes on the other side of the mountain. The shuttles bring them here. If we tax the shuttles, the foundry raises the price of the pipes. If the price goes up, we don't finish the sewer. And with all respect to your cousin's wedding, Vaelith, if we don't finish the sewer before the rainy season, clean bedsheets will be the very least of our problems."

"Call the vote, Jesse," hissed Magistrate Ssisera. She was a slender Naga judge, currently coiled in a tight, shivering knot on top of the room's single cast-iron steam radiator, her scaly crest flushed an irritable yellow. "It is the twenty-seventh hour. I am cold, my crest is peeling, and if Nimbus covers the sun before I get a hot bowl of broth, I am going to bite the next person who mentions laundry."

From the open terrace behind the council table, a deep, resonant voice chimed in:

"I rather like the smell of the rockets," the voice rumbled. It was a magnificent sound, like a cathedral pipe organ being played through three feet of warm honey. "It smells like hot iron and ambition. But Vaelith is right about the sheets, Jesse. Grey linens are dreadfully dreary."

Jesse didn't turn around. He didn't need to. Resting his massive chin comfortably on the marble balustrade of the terrace was **Goldheart**.

He was a void dragon. Out in the deep, freezing silence between the stars, he was a creature of myth and terror, a living furnace of bio-fusion capable of outrunning warships and trading blows with alien dreadnoughts. Here in Crossroads Valley, however, where he had lived since the first colony ship opened its hatches five hundred years ago, he was essentially the town's overgrown grandfather. He liked roasted apples, he liked watching the village children play in the square, and above all, he dearly loved municipal meetings. To an immortal being that fed on cosmic energy, there was something endlessly soothing about mortal politics. It was like watching someone fold origami from a legal document so that in the end you could read a haiku from the back of a paper swan. That was the ideal anyway, but the dragon appreciated the effort too.

"Thank you, Goldheart," Jesse said mildly, tapping his wooden gavel. "Your thoughts on bedsheets are, as always, deeply valued. The chair recognizes the dragon's remark. Now, all those in favor of the shuttle drainage fee—"

A horrible, high-pitched whistling shriek tore through the clouds.

It wasn't the polite, muffled hum of a licensed cargo hauler. It was the frantic, screeching howl of a small, stolen hopper engine that was on fire, missing half its thruster nozzles, and falling out of the sky far too fast.

Jesse looked up. Through the hall's stained-glass skylight—an antique window commemorating the First Landing—he saw a streak of greasy black smoke, followed immediately by two pairs of boots. An instant later, the skylight gave way with a sound like a greenhouse being dropped from an orbital crane, showering shards of antique leaded glass and splintered roof tiles across the chamber.

A body struck the center of Jesse's beloved cedar table with the dull, violent impact of a side of beef dropped from a cargo gantry, snapping the center plank clean in half and sending water pitchers, ink pots, and tax ledgers flying in all directions.

Jesse closed his eyes, took a deep breath, and counted slowly to three. When he opened them, a twitchy kid in a grease-stained leather flight jacket was scrambling backward across the ruined table, clutching a humming, glowing hunk of alien metal wrapped in a dirty burlap sack. The object was pulsing with a strange, dull rhythm that made Jesse's front teeth ache. In his other hand, the kid was waving a dented, ugly little machine pistol.

"Stay back!" the kid shrieked, his eyes wild and bloodshot. "Don't touch me! I pulled this core straight out of the old war wreck in the crater! You take one step and I crack the casing! I'll level the whole street!"

Councilwoman Vaelith stared at the wreckage of the table, her wooden spectacles askew on her nose. "Young man," she said in a tone of voice that could freeze boiling water, "you have just ruined a thirty-year-old finish."

"I don't give a damn about your furniture!" the boy screamed, waving the gun at her. "Tell those Corsairs to back off! I'm not going to the penal mines! Tell them to back off!"

Above the hole in the roof, two thick steel cables snapped taut against the iron rafters with the sharp, mechanical bite of industrial winches. Two figures dropped through the opening, hitting the stone floor with the heavy, hydraulic crunch of powered armor. They were covered in soot, their grey metal plates were scraped to bare alloy, and they looked thoroughly, profoundly exhausted.

The lead Corsair brought a heavy, snub-nosed shotgun up to their shoulder in one smooth, practiced motion. Beside them, an elven partner leveled a taser rifle.

"Iron on the floor, kid," the one holding the shotgun rasped through her helmet grille. "Don't do anything stupid. Stupid is what got you into this mess. Put down the gun and live long enough to enjoy some variety in life."

The fugitive backed frantically toward the open terrace, his knuckles white against the grip of his machine pistol. "Stay back! I mean it! One step and I crack the casing! I'll take half the block with me!"

Jesse sighed. He picked up his bent glasses, rubbed the glass dust off them, and set them on his nose.

"Young man," Jesse said politely, "you are already facing three counts of grand larceny, an unlicensed atmospheric descent, and the destruction of a thirty-year-old cedar table. Do not make this afternoon any more expensive than it already is."

The kid's face twisted into desperation. He swiveled the gun straight toward Jesse's chest. "Shut up, old man, or I—"

He didn't finish.

From the sunlit terrace outside, a massive golden foreleg—roughly the thickness of an ancient cedar trunk—reached smoothly through the broken archway. With the gentle, practiced care of someone scooping up a wayward kitten, Goldheart curled his enormous paw around the boy, lifting him six inches clean off the floorboards.

The boy's arms were pinned neatly to his ribs inside a cage of golden, mirror-polished talons. He squirmed. He kicked his heels against empty air. He might as well have been trying to wrestle a mountain range.

Goldheart lowered his enormous horned head into the room. His golden eyes, each the size of a tavern tabletop, blinked down at the suspended thief with mild, grandfatherly reproach. When he exhaled, a warm, fragrant gust of air smelling of cinnamon, summer ozone, and woodsmoke gently ruffled the boy's greasy hair and blew his cap off.

"I wouldn't shoot Jesse if I were you," the dragon rumbled pleasantly, the sound vibrating through the boy's jawbone. "He made that table himself, you know. And when Jesse gets upset, he forgets to put sugar in my tea."

The boy stared into an eye the size of a wagon wheel. His fingers went limp. The machine pistol slipped from his hand and clattered harmlessly against the floorboards. He wondered how a dragon of Goldheart's size could drink a cup of tea.

"Thank you, honoured dragon," the lead Corsair murmured, exhaling in immense relief. Stepping in swiftly, she kicked the pistol into the corner and snapped heavy magnetic cuffs over the kid's wrists as Goldheart gently set him back onto his feet. The elven scout stepped forward with a lead-lined lockbox, popped the humming alien relic inside, and slammed the latches. The thrumming in Jesse's teeth vanished instantly.

The room fell dead silent, save for the tick of the wall clock and the cold wind blowing through the shattered skylight.

Only now, with the fugitive secured, did the two Corsairs seem to fully realize where their chase had ended. They looked around at the vaulted cedar rafters, the stone-faced Craggen, the imposing Sylvan elder, the magistrate shivering on her radiator, and finally up at the colossal golden dragon resting his chin on the balcony.

The lead Corsair hurriedly unlatched her helmet with a sharp hiss of pressurized seals, pulling it off to reveal a soot-streaked face and eyes wide with sudden, flustered mortification. Her posture snapped straight, instantly shifting from hardened void commando to an apologetic schoolchild who had just kicked a ball through the cathedral's finest stained glass.

"Speaker Haddon… Council elders… Honoured Goldheart," she said, her voice dropping into a hasty, respectful bow. "We are… profoundly sorry. For the roof, for the noise, and—most especially—for him. We had him boxed in over the reservoir, but his lateral thruster blew."

Beside her, her partner tilted his head back, stared up through the gaping crater in the ceiling, and muttered under his breath: "Fuck me, is that coming out of our paycheck?"

"Shut up," she hissed out the side of her mouth, bowing even lower toward Jesse. "The Corsair Oversight Committee will cover all structural damages, of course. Full restitution to the municipal treasury within two weeks."

Jesse looked at the broken glass. Then he looked up through the hole in the ceiling.

Outside, the enormous dark curve of Nimbus was sliding cleanly across the face of the sun. The amber sunlight faded into a soft, bruised violet. Down in the square, the gas streetlamps lit with a series of muffled *pops*, their yellow flames flickering in the chilly mountain breeze. *The Pause* had begun.

Jesse picked up the handle of his broken gavel and tapped it against the cedar stump.

"Take him down to the cellar lockup," Jesse said wearily. "Council is adjourned for the eclipse. We'll vote on the sewage pipes once the sun comes back."

Goldheart purred, tucked his great golden snout under his wing on the terrace, and went to sleep in the dark.